

Riyadh Season: what their public marketing signals are actually saying

A short, evidence-based read of ticketing and booking mechanics — not internal data I don't have access to.

How this was built: every point below is checkable by anyone, using official ticketing announcements and event listings across different editions of the season. Nothing here claims insight into revenue, attendance, or internal reporting — this is scoped strictly to booking mechanics.

1. The ticketing platform itself has changed

- Earlier editions sold tickets directly through RiyadhSeason.com. A later edition designated WeBook as the sole official ticketing platform — a real, announced change in booking infrastructure between editions.
- A returning visitor who bookmarked the old process has a genuine reason to land in the wrong place first.

2. Zone-by-zone booking rules vary

- Across dozens of zones and events, some require advance reservation and others don't — consistently described as "check the official website" rather than one visible rule set.
- For an event spanning months and multiple sites, that's a real cognitive load shifted onto the visitor each time they plan a new zone.

3. A large third-party guide industry fills a real gap

- Multiple independent travel sites publish their own "ultimate guide" to the season — what's on, how to book, what to expect — not just once, but as a recurring content category.
- That volume of explainer content is itself a signal: enough visitors are searching for a plain answer that official channels alone aren't fully solving.

4. No single "what's on today" view is easy to find

- With millions of tickets sold across many zones, the natural visitor question — what's actually happening today, across all of it — doesn't have an obvious single answer surfaced in what's publicly indexed.
- Each zone and event tends to be discovered separately, rather than through one unified, current schedule.

What this pattern usually means: an event operating at this scale, across this many physical zones and this many months, will always outgrow whatever booking structure it started with. None of this is unusual for something this size. It's the kind of gap that's cheap to close — a single current schedule, and a stable platform visitors don't have to relearn — and expensive to leave, in the form of confused visitors and a permanent cottage industry of unofficial guides doing the job the official site could do once, itself.

What I'd check first, in order

- 1 Redirect any legacy ticketing URLs to the current platform.** A returning visitor should never land on a dead end from a previous edition.

- 2 Publish one unified, live "what's on today" view.** Across every zone, in one place — the single feature that would make most third-party guides redundant.

- 3 State the reservation requirement on every zone's own page.** "Check the official website" should be replaced by the answer itself, on the page the visitor is already reading.



Faisal Mahmud

FRACTIONAL MARKETING DIRECTOR

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